



Making a comeback: Radha Yadav has played 89 T20Is and has taken 103 wickets since her debut in 2018, and will be playing her fifth T20 World Cup. PTI

allrounder who combined speed and accuracy with the ball and power with the bat, and will she return?

Fast-tracking Nandni, who emerged from WPL 2026 as the joint-highest wicket-taker with 17 scalps in 10 matches, including a hat-trick and a five-wicket haul, addresses part of that concern. The selectors have backed her all-phase bowling ability and versatility. She has even hinted on social media that she can contribute with the bat, something that may prove valuable in English conditions.

This gap has also reopened the door for Radha, part of the ODI World Cup-winning side but someone who last played a T20I in July last year, also in England. During India's experimental phase in bilateral series, she was often reduced to a glorified fielding substitute. However, her contributions to Royal Challengers Bengaluru's WPL triumph and her leadership of India A to victory in the Rising Stars Asia Cup have

strengthened her case. With four World Cups behind her, Radha's experience adds weight.

Second wind?

India's 1-4 loss in South Africa served as a timely reminder of the instability that still lingers in the format.

While Amita described the bowling performance as "disappointing", Harmanpreet defended her unit: "In the T20 format, it's a hard job for bowlers. Wickets were batter-friendly, but still, they tried their best. After the last T20 World Cup, we have won every T20 series. I can't judge my players on one series."

What went largely unnoticed was an underwhelming showing from the batters. While Harmanpreet and Shafali Verma carried the side, Smriti Mandhana struggled for consistency and was even benched for two games, where debutant Anushka Sharma replaced her. This may have been down to workload management and rotation, but given she ultimately did not make the squad, the decision remains curious.

Bharti Fulmali's handling was equally puzzling. A player known for her finishing ability, she might have benefited from being given more responsibility. In an ideal scenario,



India squad

Harmanpreet Kaur (captain), Smriti Mandhana, Shafali Verma, Jemimah Rodrigues, Bharti Fulmali, Deepti Sharma, Richa Ghosh, Shree Charani, Yastika Bhatia, Nandani Sharma, Arundhati Reddy, Renuka Singh, Kranti Gaud, Shreyanka Patil, Radha Yadav

she could have been promoted ahead of Richa to ease into the role. However, Richa's own need for rhythm created a catch-22.

Yastika's return is particularly poignant. A sprightly left-hander capable of dictating the tempo, the 25-year-old's career has been repeatedly disrupted by injuries, the latest being an ACL surgery in October last year. She last played a T20I in 2024. Her selection effectively shuts the door on Uma Chetry and G. Kamalini, neither of whom established themselves as reliable alternatives to Richa.

With a fairly settled top four, Yastika also offers a middle-order alternative to someone like Harleen Deol, who struggled to maintain the scoring rate required to hold her place in the T20 side.

India has attempted to address key gaps ahead of the 2026 showpiece, where its campaign begins against Pakistan at Edgbaston. Harmanpreet emphasised the importance of maximising the PowerPlay in a format where teams continue to evolve.

The 2020 T20 World Cup finalist faces a challenging group featuring Australia, South Africa, Bangladesh, Pakistan, and the Netherlands. The group-stage exit in 2024 would have been sobering enough, where India's promise failed to translate into results.

This time, the setup has chosen to look beyond inexperience and back skill. The question now is whether that faith will be rewarded.